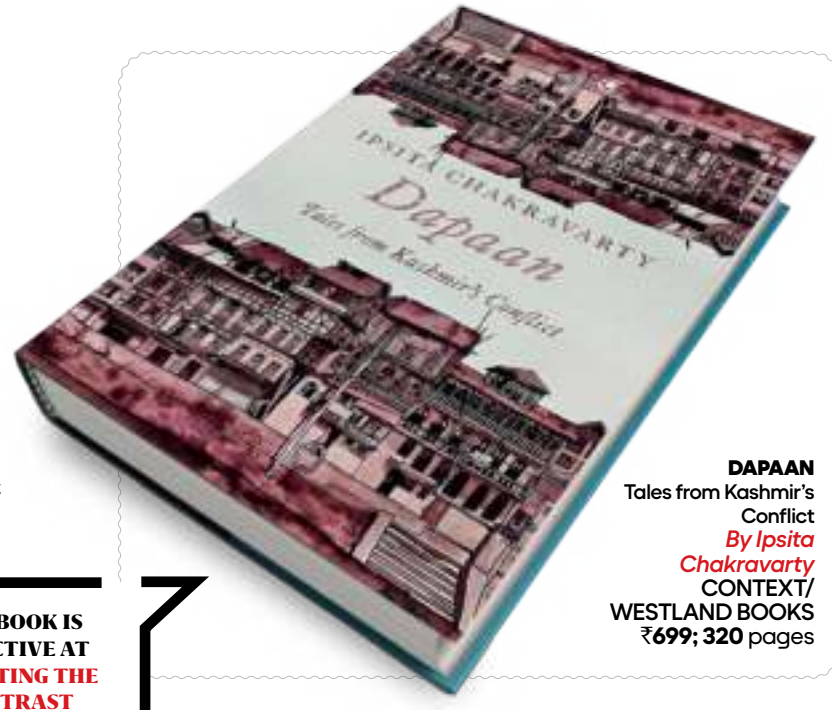
BOOKS ▶

TALE ABOUT TALES

DAPAAN EXPLORES KASHMIR'S STORYTELLING TRADITIONS AND THE STORIES KASHMIRIS HAVE BEEN TELLING EACH OTHER IN A TIME OF CONFLICT

At around the 50-page mark in *Dapaan*, Ipsita Chakravarty's nonfiction book about Kashmir, there's a brilliant passage where the author reproduces part of a *bhand paether* (a Kashmiri folk theatre form) skit. An armed soldier, looking for a man named Gani, is shocked when the man's brother at the door calls out for "Gun Kak" (or 'gun uncle'). The soldier, sputtering with rage, asks "gun cocked?", before beating up Gani. This bit of Kafkaesque tragicomedy has been a part of *bhand* artists' repertoire since the 1990s, as Chakravarty tells us.



DAPAAN
Tales from Kashmir's Conflict
By Ipsita Chakravarty
CONTEXT/ WESTLAND BOOKS
₹699; 320 pages

Dapaan gets its name from a Kashmiri word often uttered at the beginning of a folktale, meaning 'it is said'. This is a book of stories-about-stories, especially in terms of how people incorporate traditional forms of storytelling (like *bhand paether* or *dastangoi*) into their memories of tumultuous times—and for Kashmiris, the past three-four decades have been relentlessly tumultuous. We learn how tragic loss and despair are filtered through seemingly innocuous songs and chants, how collective fears about war, surveillance and imprisonment are manifested in the form of ghost stories, how we end up with urban legends about restless spirits looking for closure.

THE BOOK IS EFFECTIVE AT DEPICTING THE CONTRAST BETWEEN THE DREAMS OF YOUTH IN KASHMIR AND THOSE IN THE REST OF INDIA

Chakravarty is an old-school reporter, and therefore she uses first-person recollections as the connective tissue between disparate narrative strands, amplifying the emotional notes. We hear from people who have lived through successive waves of militarisation, from artists and students and all manner of regular, everyday folks just trying to make a living through the ever-shifting, heightened political stakes and the ensuing media scrutiny. These memory-centric portions delve into some pretty bleak stuff, but they're never trite or maudlin in their portrayals. For example, Chapter 11, 'The Trials of Majnun', uses the Laila-Majnun story as the semantic scaffolding to tell us two intertwined stories simultaneously: the decline of Kashmir's *daastangohs* and the rise of militancy in the region. Chakravarty maintains this delicate balance with admirable restraint—and occasionally, lyrical flourishes.

"The *haalaat* arrived in Kashmir as their own kind of fever dream, turning everyone into Majnun. Everyone was now *deewana*, ecstatic, with the fear of death and with visions of *aazadi*, which had taken on the features of a different dimension, not just an altered political state."

Dapaan is, therefore, especially effective when depicting the stark divergence between the hopes and dreams of Kashmiri youth—and what the rest of the country sees as 'aspirational'. Alongside Mehek Jamal's *Loal Kashmir*, another excellent nonfiction title released recently, *Dapaan* is highly recommended, especially for those who like their nonfiction asymmetric and impressionistic. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha